DFIR REPORT BREAKDOWN

From a Bing search to full domain ransomware in 44 hours

How Bumblebee and AdaptixC2 quietly delivered Akira across an entire Active Directory.

SOURCE

The DFIR Report June 2026

Mohammed Rida Lakhdari

Learning in Public · Purple Team

THE STORY IN ONE LINE

One admin looked for a monitoring tool. Five days later the whole domain was encrypted.

44 h	~5 days	~77 GB
to ransomware	attacker dwell time	data stolen first

A clean, fast, identity-driven intrusion. Here is how each stage unfolded, and where a SOC could have caught it.

STAGE 01 · INITIAL ACCESS

Poisoned search results, not a phishing email

- An IT admin searched Bing for ManageEngine OpManager.
- A lookalike site (opmanager[.]pro) redirected to a fake download center.
- The trojanized MSI installed the real OpManager as a decoy, while quietly dropping the Bumblebee loader.
- The admin even moved the installer to a network share before running it.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1189 T1204.002

STAGE 02 · THE LOADER

Bumblebee hides behind a trusted Windows binary

- consent.exe was side-loaded with a malicious msimg32.dll from %TEMP%.
- The loader checked the machine locale against CIS regions before running.
- It then beaconed out to algorithm-generated (DGA) domains.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1574.001 T1027.010

STAGE 03 · COMMAND & CONTROL

AdaptixC2 lands inside a WMI process

- ~5 hours in, a renamed WAB.exe was launched through WMI, so it spawned under WmiPrvSE.exe.
- Shellcode was injected, giving an AdaptixC2 HTTP beacon on a default profile.
- Quick discovery followed: systeminfo, nltest, whoami, ping, then a full network scan.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1055 T1047 T1071.001

STAGE 04 · CREDENTIAL ACCESS

Straight to Enterprise Admin

- Rogue accounts backup_DA and backup_EA were created; backup_EA joined Enterprise Admins.
- ntds.dit plus SYSTEM and SECURITY hives were copied with wbadmin.
- Veeam credentials were dumped via psql and DPAPI; LSASS was dumped remotely on three hosts.
- No privilege escalation needed. They held domain admin from the start of lateral movement.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1003.001 T1003.003 T1136 T1555

STAGE 05 · LATERAL & PERSISTENCE

Spread wide, then settle in

- RDP was used across nine different accounts, some tunneled through a reverse SSH connection.
- RustDesk was installed as a service on servers for durable remote access.
- SoftPerfect Netscan and Invoke-ShareFinder mapped hosts and shares.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1021.001 T1219 T1090

STAGE 06 · EXFIL & IMPACT

Steal everything, then detonate

- Around 77 GB was exfiltrated over SFTP using FileZilla.
- Akira (locker.exe) was deployed: backup server first, then the root domain, then the child DC two days later.
- Shadow copies were deleted via WMI, and FileZilla was uninstalled to remove evidence.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1048.001 T1486 T1490

WHERE A SOC CATCHES THIS

Six places defenders could have broken the chain

- consent.exe running from %TEMP% or AppData (execution-location anomaly).
- Unbacked RWX memory in WAB.exe / AdgNsy.exe; Sysmon Event ID 10 to the injected process.
- WmiPrvSE.exe spawning unusual child processes.
- net group "enterprise admins" /add and the built-in Administrator being reactivated.
- wbadmin touching ntds.dit; comsvcs.dll MiniDump via rundll32.
- ssh -R from a domain controller; Win32_Shadowcopy deletion.

WHAT I TOOK AWAY

Three lessons for blue teams

1 **SEO poisoning now rivals phishing.**
Even careful admins get hit through a search bar.

2 **Identity is the real battleground.**
One host to Enterprise Admin in a few hours, with no exploit.

3 **Detection beats prevention here.**
Injection, odd parent-child chains and account creation were all visible.

Which of these would your detections have caught first?
Full report: The DFIR Report (June 2026)